PUY LENTILS WITH AUBERGINE, TOMATOES AND YOGHURT

4 - aubergines, pricked a few times with a knife (1.1kg)

300g - cherry tomatoes

160g - Puy lentils (or 350g ready-cooked lentils, if you want to save time)

2 tbsp - olive oil, plus extra to drizzle

1½ tbsp - lemon juice

1 - small garlic clove, crushed

3 tbsp - picked oregano leaves

100g - Greek-style yoghurt

salt and black pepper

SERVES FOUR AS A STARTER OR SIDE, TWO AS A MAIN

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ABOUT

For the sake of ease I've roasted the aubergines here in a hot oven. If you want to really get a smoky taste into the flesh of the aubergine, though, you're best to put it directly on the open flame on your stove. I line my stove top with foil when doing this (making holes for the flames to come through), then use long tongs to help turn the aubergine so that all sides get burnt. This method can be a bit messy, but the upside is that it takes just 15–20 minutes, rather than an hour, and the resulting smoky taste is more intense. This can be made up to 3 days in advance, up to the point of the yoghurt being added. Keep in the fridge until needed.

METHOD

1. Preheat the oven to 230°C fan or as high as your oven will go.
2. Place the aubergines on a baking tray and roast for 1 hour, turning them over halfway through, until the flesh is completely soft and slightly smoky. Remove from the oven and, once cool enough handle, scoop the flesh out into a colander. Set aside, in the sink or over a bowl, for 30 minutes, for any liquid to drain away. The skin can be discarded.
3. Place the cherry tomatoes on the same tray and roast for 12 minutes, until slightly blackened, split and soft. Remove and set aside.
4. Meanwhile, if starting with uncooked lentils, fill a medium saucepan with plenty of water and place on a high heat. Once boiling, add the lentils, lower the heat to medium and cook for 20 minutes, until soft but still retaining a bite. Drain, then set aside to dry out slightly. If starting with ready-cooked lentils, just tip them into a large bowl and add the aubergine flesh, tomatoes, oil, lemon juice, garlic, 2 tablespoons of oregano, ¾ teaspoon of salt and a good grind of pepper. Mix well, then spoon into a large shallow bowl. Top with the yoghurt, swirling it through slightly so there are obvious streaks. Sprinkle over the remaining tablespoon of oregano, drizzle with a little oil, and serve.